

CONCUSSIONS IN STUDENTS AND STUDENT-ATHLETES

Loudoun County Public Schools supports the need to ensure that our staff, students, and community are aware of the seriousness of brain injuries and concussions and how they can affect the student's abilities in the educational setting. LCPS is committed to ensuring that students participating in school sponsored activities who sustain concussions are properly diagnosed, given adequate time to heal, and are comprehensively supported until they are symptom-free.

A. Definitions.

1. Concussion. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) a concussion is a type of traumatic brain injury—or TBI—caused by a bump, blow, or jolt to the head or by a hit to the body that causes the head and brain to move rapidly back and forth. This sudden movement can cause the brain to bounce around or twist in the skull, creating chemical changes in the brain and sometimes stretching and damaging brain cells.

2. Licensed Health Care Provider. A physician, physician's assistant, osteopath, or an athletic trainer licensed by the Virginia Board of Medicine; a neuropsychologist licensed by the Board of Psychology; or a nurse practitioner licensed by the Virginia State Board of Nursing.

3. Return-to-Learn. Instructional modifications that support a controlled, progressive increase in cognitive activities while the student recovers from a brain injury allowing the student or student-athlete to participate in classroom activities and learn without worsening symptoms and potentially delaying healing.

4. Return-to-Play. Participate in a supervised practice or competition.

B. Concussion in Students.

1. If a student suffers a head injury during the school day or during school activities, school personnel shall:

a. Non-Student Health Services Staff should:

- (i) Call 911 if there is a reason to suspect a concussion or other serious head injury
- (ii) Provide first-aid as trained
- (iii) Contact the School Nurse, Health Clinic Specialists (HCS), or trainer, if accessible
- (iv) Notify the parent/guardian

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b. Student Health Services staff will:

- (i) Follow the Virginia Department of Health flip chart and LCPS procedure.
- (ii) Call 911 if appropriate
- (iii) Notify the parent/guardian

2. If any student's head injury is determined to be a concussion or impacts the student's access to learning, school personnel shall accommodate the student's return to learn based on recommendations from a licensed health care provider and shall take into consideration cognitive and academic issues that may be experienced by a student who has suffered a concussion or other head injury, including (i) difficulty with concentration, organization, and long-term and short-term memory; (ii) sensitivity to bright lights and sounds; (iii) short-term problems with speech and language, reasoning, processing, planning and problem solving, and (iv) balance or other physical deficits.

C. Concussion in Students-Athletes.

1. Concussion Management Team.

- a. At the direction of the superintendent or designee, LCPS shall form a division-wide Concussion Management Team (CMT). The committee will be comprised of two high school administrators; two high school athletic administrators; two medically licensed athletic trainers; Supervisor of Student Health Services; Supervisor of Athletics; high school coach; high school parent/guardian; and high school student-athlete. The Supervisor of Athletics shall be responsible for scheduling this annual review.
- b. The CMT shall meet at least once per year.
- c. The CMT will review training materials for school personnel, volunteers, student-athletes and parents/guardians of student's athletes that has been developed by the Office of Athletics.
- d. The CMT will evaluate training materials, concussion reporting, management and review protocols as developed by the Office of Athletics, annually.

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2. Eligibility. In order to participate in any interscholastic athletic activity, each student-athlete and the student-athlete's parent or guardian(s) shall review, on an annual basis (every 12 months), information on concussions provided by Loudoun County Public Schools.

After having reviewed materials describing the short- and long-term health effects of concussions, each student-athlete and the student-athlete's parent or guardian shall sign a statement acknowledging receipt, review, and understanding of such information.

The Division Superintendent, or designee, will determine procedures for ensuring, annually, that statements are distributed to, and collected from each student-athlete their parent(s)/guardian(s) with appropriate signatures.

3. Required Concussion Training for School Personnel and Volunteers. The Division Superintendent or designee will develop procedures to ensure school staff, coaches, assistant coaches, athletic trainers, team physicians, and volunteers or other persons serving in a coaching or advisory role over students-athletes during games shall receive current training annually on:

- a. how to recognize the signs and symptoms of a concussion;
- b. strategies to reduce the risk of concussions;
- c. how to seek proper medical treatment for a person suspected of having a concussion; and
- d. when the student-athlete may safely return to practice or competition.

LCPS will maintain a tracking system to document compliance with the annual training requirement.

Annual training on concussion management shall use a reputable program such as, but not limited to, those listed in the accompanying regulation.

4. Baseline Testing. Baseline testing is required and conducted for student-athlete as outlined in Regulation 8445. LCPS assumes the cost of the required baseline tests.

5. Removal from Activity.

- a. A student-athlete suspected by that student-athlete's coach, athletic trainer, or team physician of sustaining a concussion or brain injury in a practice, game, or competition shall be removed from the activity immediately, evaluated and, if necessary, referred for further treatment.

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- b. A student-athlete who has been removed from play, evaluated, and suspected to have a concussion or brain injury shall not return to play that same day nor until (i) evaluated by an appropriate licensed health care provider as determined by the Board of Education and (ii) in receipt of written clearance to return to play from such licensed health care provider.
- c. Appropriate licensed health care providers or properly trained individuals evaluating student-athletes at the time of injury will utilize a standardized concussion sideline assessment instrument, including, but not limited to, those described in the accompanying regulation.
- d. The coach of a student-athlete may elect not to return the student-athlete to extracurricular physical activity, even if after the concussion assessment is determined that the student-athlete is no longer suspected of having sustained a concussion, if they observe signs or symptoms of a concussion.

6. Return-to-Play Protocol.

- a. No student-athlete shall be allowed to return to any practice, game or competition the same day he or she is injured and:
 - (i) exhibits signs, symptoms or behaviors consistent with a concussion; or
 - (ii) has been diagnosed with a concussion.
- b. No member of a school athletic team shall return to participate in any practice, game, or competition on the days after they experience a concussion unless all of the following conditions have been met:
 - (i) the student-athlete no longer exhibits signs, symptoms or behaviors consistent with a concussion, at rest or with exertion;
 - (ii) the student-athlete is asymptomatic during, or following periods of supervised exercise that is gradually intensifying; and
 - (iii) the student-athlete receives a written medical release from a licensed health care provider.

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7. Return-to-Learn Protocol.

- a. School personnel shall be alert to cognitive and academic issues that may be experienced by a student-athlete who has suffered a concussion or other head injury, including (i) difficulty with concentration, organization and long-term and short-term memory; (ii) sensitivity to bright lights and sounds; and (iii) short-term problems with speech and language, reasoning, planning and problem solving.
- b. School personnel shall accommodate the gradual return to full participation in academic activities by a student-athlete who has suffered a concussion or other head injury as appropriate, based on the recommendation of the student-athletes licensed health care provider as to the appropriate amount of time that such student-athlete needs to be away from the classroom.

8. Helmets.

- a. Helmets used in LCPS activities must be National Operating Committee on Standards for Athletic Equipment (NOCSAE) certified by the manufacturer at the time of purchase.
- b. Reconditioned helmets used in LCPS activities must be NOCSAE recertified by the reconditioner.

9. Community Involvement. At no cost to LCPS, reasonable efforts should be made to provide materials and training opportunities related to concussion management to organizations sponsoring athletic activity for student-athletes on school property.

[Former Policy 8-58]

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Leg. Ref: [§22.1-271.5](#) of the Code of Virginia. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), 2020